

Gmail Integration for CRM

Feature Overview and Deep Instruction

OpenAI

\$(date +%Y-%m-%d)

Executive overview

This feature turns the CRM into a connected communication workspace. A platform administrator stores the Google app credentials once in system settings, while each company user connects their own Gmail account through a familiar OAuth flow. After authorization, the CRM syncs Gmail threads and messages so teams can track conversations with leads, contacts, and customers without leaving the CRM.

The intended experience should feel similar to Brevo Conversations: the connection starts from a clean button, account selection happens on Google, tokens are handled by the backend, and the CRM presents a clear mailbox status, sync status, and conversation history.

Recommended principle: keep the first release focused on fetching and organizing emails well before expanding into advanced sending, shared inbox logic, or automation rules.

Quick summary

Area	Description
Document purpose	Provide a practical overview of a Brevo-style Gmail connection feature for a CRM after Google Cloud and OAuth setup are complete.
Primary outcome	Users can click Connect Gmail , choose a Google account, authorize access, and see Gmail conversations inside the CRM.
Recommended MVP	Read-only mailbox sync first, then add send/reply after the inbox flow is stable.

1. Product vision

The feature should allow a CRM user to connect a personal or work Gmail account and see relevant email conversations from inside the CRM. The CRM becomes a communication layer that sits beside leads, contacts, deals, and customer records.

The business value is straightforward: email history is no longer trapped inside personal inboxes, the team gains context, and customer communication can be reviewed inside the same system that manages leads and pipelines.

2. Core roles

- **Superadmin or system owner** - configures the Google integration once in CRM settings and controls whether the feature is available.
- **Company admin** - can monitor which users have connected Gmail, see status, and support reconnect or disconnect tasks.
- **Company user** - connects an individual Gmail account and uses the synced mailbox inside the CRM.

3. End-user experience

1. The user opens the CRM mailbox or company communication area and clicks **Connect Gmail**.
2. The CRM redirects the user to Google, where the account chooser and consent screen appear.
3. The user picks a Gmail account and approves the requested permissions.
4. The backend exchanges the authorization code for tokens and stores the connection securely.
5. The CRM returns the user to a Gmail connection page that shows the connected account, status, and first sync progress.
6. The CRM loads email threads and starts matching them to leads, contacts, or deals where possible.

4. Feature modules

Module	What it does	Why it matters
System settings	Stores Google Client ID, Client Secret, redirect URI, enabled scopes, and integration toggles.	Lets the platform owner configure Gmail once for the whole CRM.
Connect Gmail	Allows a company user to authorize their own Gmail account with Google OAuth.	Matches the Brevo-style one-click connection experience.
Mailbox sync	Pulls threads, messages, senders, recipients, snippets, and timestamps into the CRM.	Creates a unified customer communication history.
Conversation view	Shows email threads inside the CRM and links them to leads, contacts, or deals.	Reduces context switching and keeps teams aligned.
Reply and send	Lets users respond from the CRM using the connected Gmail account.	Turns the CRM into an operational inbox, not just a viewer.
Connection health	Displays connected account status, last sync, token errors, reconnect, and disconnect actions.	Makes the feature manageable for users and support teams.

5. Recommended UI structure

Settings level

- **Settings -> Integrations -> Gmail**
- Fields: Enable Integration, Google Client ID, Google Client Secret, Redirect URI, allowed scopes, sync interval, and environment label.
- Status helpers: Test connection, last updated, app environment, and verification notes for admins.

Company or user level

- **Company -> Email Channels -> Gmail or My Account -> Connected Channels**
- Primary actions: Connect Gmail, Reconnect, Sync now, Disconnect.
- Status cards: connected email, last sync, sync health, permissions granted, and any token or authorization issues.

6. Technical flow overview

A clean implementation is split into system credentials, user authorization, token storage, and mailbox sync.

Stage	What happens
System credentials	The superadmin stores Google Client ID, Client Secret, redirect URI, and enabled scopes in CRM settings.
OAuth start	The Connect Gmail button calls a backend endpoint that redirects the user to Google with the chosen scopes.
OAuth callback	Google returns an authorization code to the backend callback URI.
Token exchange	The backend exchanges the code for access and refresh tokens, then links them to the CRM user.
Mailbox sync	The backend calls Gmail APIs to list threads, fetch messages, and store CRM-friendly records.
Presentation layer	The CRM displays connected mailbox status, synced threads, and customer-linked conversations.

7. Suggested data model

Table	Purpose
integration_settings_google	Stores global Google app credentials and feature flags.
company_gmail_accounts	Stores one or more user-authorized Gmail connections per CRM user or company.
email_threads	Stores Gmail thread IDs mapped to CRM contacts, leads, or deals.
email_messages	Stores normalized message records for inbox display and history.
email_sync_logs	Stores sync attempts, results, and error messages for debugging and support.

8. Security and operational notes

- Store Google Client Secret only in protected system settings, never in the frontend.
- Encrypt refresh tokens at rest and keep access tokens short-lived.
- Use backend-only OAuth code exchange and validate the state parameter.
- Provide reconnect and disconnect actions so users can recover from revoked or expired permissions.
- For production, align requested Gmail scopes with the smallest practical permission set for the feature.

9. Recommended release path

- **Phase 1** - Connect Gmail and sync read-only inbox data.
- **Phase 2** - Add conversation linking to leads, contacts, and deals.
- **Phase 3** - Add reply and send from CRM once threading and mailbox sync are stable.

- **Phase 4** - Add shared inbox workflows, assignment rules, templates, and analytics only after the fundamentals are reliable.

10. Final implementation direction

The best product design for this feature is: one Google app configuration in CRM settings, individual Gmail authorization per user, secure backend token handling, and a conversation view inside the CRM that feels simple, reliable, and familiar. This gives your CRM a Brevo-style connection experience while still following the correct Gmail authorization model.

Prepared as a high-level feature overview for product planning, UI design, and development handoff.